

Who decides what ships

"Which AI agent should we buy?" is the *second* question. The first – **who owns this, and how do we decide what ships?** – is the one that predicts whether the project survives. When these programs get cancelled, **four of the five reasons are governance and ownership. Only one is technical.**



FIVE SIGNS YOU'RE MISSING GOVERNANCE only 1 of 5 is technical

- 1

No decision rights
Nobody can say which projects start or stop – or who's accountable when an agent makes a bad call.
- 2

No use-case gate
Every team wants an agent, so the program spreads across a dozen weak candidates instead of two strong ones.
- 3

Broken data underneath
The agent works from records that don't agree with each other.

THE TECHNICAL ONE, LAYER 2
- 4

Runaway cost
Tokens, orchestration, human review and vendor fees add up quietly, and the bill arrives after the budget is set.
- 5

No owner after launch
The pilot team moves on, the agent keeps running, and six months later it's quietly wrong with nobody watching.

Governance is a **small team of three to eight people who can decide quickly**. It owns the decision rights, the use-case gate, and the lifecycle:

Decision rights · the GO / PILOT / PARK use-case gate · intake to run to retire lifecycle

Say **no** quickly, with a reason; a slow **maybe** gets built anyway, out of sight.

TIER THE AUTONOMY TO WHAT'S AT STAKE the mistake: L3 autonomy · L0 controls



Monday morning

YOUR FIRST MOVE

Write a name – **today, without a meeting** – next to each of the six decision rights:

1 Which use-cases get built

2 Production rollout sign-off

3 Budget

4 Risk acceptance

5 Model & prompt changes

6 Integrations

It takes an afternoon. Self-check: who accepts the risk if the agent acts and gets it wrong? If you hesitated, that's your gap.

OPERATOR INSIGHT · LAYER 1

Governance doesn't slow AI down - it's what lets AI scale.

"Your AI maturity will never exceed your operational maturity."

Free **Score your own org** – the AI-Ready Operations Assessment turns this episode into a check you can run (maturity scale: *ad hoc* to *AI-ready*). vihrenlabs.gumroad.com/l/rmkje